

In Europe, the broad principles of military tradition evolved out of the medieval concept of chivalry. Across Europe, however, a number of different traditions developed. In the United Kingdom and its empire, the tradition was maintained by the regiments, with each one tracing its own history back to the date of its formation. In Prussia and subsequently in the German Empire, states relied more on their own history as a state, although certain regiments within elite formations did maintain unit histories. The French, meanwhile, created the concept of *esprit de corps*, or pride in one's unit, within most elite or unique French units.

But a single thread, a bond forged by history, group ritual, and an invisible force of willing obligation runs through all these traditions. It is because of this thread, this common need, that the manner in which states and societies have raised and organized their fighting forces across the continents of the world has remained essentially the same for over two thousand years.

Soldier takes you through the story of this martial tradition. It features 30 key individual soldiers and warriors, including sailors and airmen, with over 70 others covered in lesser detail. These include not only the fighting elites of great empires, but also inexperienced conscripts and volunteers. For each of the key soldiers there is a full account of their organization and equipment with insights into their motivation and an assessment of their achievements. This will allow you to sense the spirit of the Greek hoplite convinced that there was nothing finer in life than to stand in a phalanx bristling with 2.7m (8ft) spears, see the remote outposts of the Roman Empire through the eyes of a legionary, and understand the confidence of the British redcoats standing fast, loading and firing more quickly and accurately than their foes. More modern armies are featured too, allowing you to trace the unbroken thread of daring, obedience, and skill that links the soldiers of every period of human history.

COLONEL TIM COLLINS

